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BREAKING NEWS AT CHICAGOTRIBUNE.COM

Trump ponders end to FEMA

President reiterates he seeks concessions for aid to California

By Will Weissert, Chris Megerian and Makiya Seminera
Associated Press

LOS ANGELES — President Donald Trump surveyed disaster zones in California and North Carolina on Friday and said he was considering “getting rid of” the Federal Emergency Management Agency, offering the latest sign of how he is weighing sweeping changes to the nation’s central organization for responding to disasters.

Instead of having federal financial assistance flow through FEMA, the Republican president said Washington could provide money directly to the states. He made the comments while visiting North Carolina, which is still recovering months after Hurricane Helene, on the first trip of his second term.

“FEMA has been a very big disappointment,” the Republican president said. “It’s very bureaucratic. And it’s very slow.”

Trump said Michael Whatley, a North Carolina native and chair of the Republican National Committee, would help coordinate recovery efforts in the state, where frustrations over the federal response have lingered. Although Whatley does not hold an official government position, Trump said he would be “very much in charge.”

While the president emphasized his desire to help North Carolina, a battleground state that voted for him in all of his presidential campaigns, he was much less generous toward California, where he arrived to visit wildfire-ravaged Los

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WATER EXPERTS PUSH BACK: As President Donald Trump prepared a Friday visit to California, water experts there said his explanations that cast blame on state officials for a series of deadly wildfires in many cases were wrong or glossed over complexities.
Nation & World

Reported ICE visit to city elementary school actually Secret Service, officials say

Agents turned away, but Southwest Side community on edge amid Trump threats

‘Fear and chaos’



Students leave Hamline Elementary School after dismissal on Friday in Chicago. Chicago Public Schools announced it blocked federal immigration officers from going into the school earlier in the day but later found it was Secret Service investigating a threat. **AUDREY RICHARDSON/CHICAGO TRIBUNE**

State senator asks prison workers for secret information to pass on to ICE

By Jeremy Gorner
Chicago Tribune

SPRINGFIELD — A downstate Republican lawmaker is urging Illinois prison employees to secretly send her information on undocumented immigrants who are behind bars so she can pass the information on to federal immigration authorities, raising concerns from a civil liberties group that she’s encouraging the workers to circumvent the state’s sanctuary law.

“If you are (Illinois Department of Corrections) staff who wants ICE to know of an illegal immigrant in IDOC call or message me,” state Sen. Terri Bryant of Murphysboro wrote in posts on X earlier this week. “I won’t rat you out. I will notify ICE.”

Bryant’s messages were posted two days after President Donald Trump took office and vowed to immediately crack down on illegal immigration by authorizing Immigration and Customs Enforcement officers to conduct mass deportation missions in Chicago and other sanctuary cities.

Bryant, who was a Trump delegate at last year’s

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EXPELLING MIGRANTS: The Trump administration is giving ICE officials the power to quickly deport migrants who were allowed into the country temporarily under Biden-era programs, according to an internal government memo obtained by The New York Times. The memo provides ICE officials a road map to use expansive powers long reserved only for encounters at the Mexico border. About 1.4 million migrants entered the country through the two programs since the beginning of 2023, officials say.
Nation & World in Business, Page 5

By Rebecca Johnson, Nell Salzman, Caroline Kubzansky and Jeremy Gorner
Chicago Tribune

A reported sighting of immigration agents attempting to enter an elementary school on Chicago’s Southwest Side on Friday was actually Secret Service agents investigating a threat, a federal spokesperson said late Friday afternoon.

This announcement came hours after leaders at Chicago Public Schools announced they blocked federal immigration officers from going into Hamline Elementary School in the New City neighborhood and talking to students, leading to swift responses from city and state leaders and immigration advocates.

Principal Natasha Ortega said at a Friday afternoon news conference that U.S. Immigration and Customs Enforcement agents showed up to the school, located at 1548 W. 48th St., at 11:15 a.m. She said school employees “followed the protocols that we’ve been trained and practiced and have discussed,” ensuring students’ safety.

“We will not open our doors for ICE, and we are here to protect our children and make sure they have access to an excellent education,” Ortega said. “We stand in solidarity with our families and the Back of the Yards community.”

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INSIDE



CHRIS SWEDA/CHICAGO TRIBUNE

Giving Sox fans something to cheer about

White Sox fans, including Joseph Seaman, center, cheer as former pitcher Mark Buehrle is introduced on stage during SoxFest Live at the Ramova Theatre in Chicago’s Bridgeport neighborhood on Friday. The annual event gave fans a chance to get a glimpse at top pitching prospects Noah Schultz and Hagen Smith, who are eager to make an impression as nonroster invitees to White Sox camp. **Chicago Sports**

Defense for Madigan says feds relying on cynicism

By Jason Meisner, Megan Crepeau and Ray Long
Chicago Tribune

Attorneys for Michael Madigan opened their final bid to persuade jurors of his innocence by harking back to a memorable nickname for the former House speaker: the Sphinx.

“The Sphinx is, of course, a mythical creature,” attorney Dan Collins said Friday as his closing argument finally got underway in a packed federal courtroom. “Quiet, mysterious. A myth. In this case, ladies and gentlemen, the government sees the myth. They do not see the man.”

The defense throughout Madigan’s marathon public corruption trial has tried to portray the longtime political

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ACLU has warning for U. of I. amid policy shifts

By Zareen Syed
Chicago Tribune

Before University of Illinois Urbana-Champaign student Gabi DalSanto was cleared to register for spring classes after being placed on a recent academic hold for defying school policy during a student-led climate march, she filed stacks of paperwork, worked with a case manager and wrote a several-page essay on what she would do differently in the future.

“It felt like what you would do in detention — it was crazy,” DalSanto said. “It shows a really big shift in the university’s outlook on expressive action.”

DalSanto, a second-year environmental science major at U. of I., was among members of the Students for Environ-

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